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VALLEY SEAT - Zine abruptly ends campaign for Assembly - Two weeks after entering, former L.A. councilman says he has a better offer

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Only two weeks after he sprang a surprise by declaring his candidacy for the state Assembly, Dennis Zine produced a shocker by announcing it's over.

The former Los Angeles city councilman said Monday afternoon that he's quitting the race for an April 3 special election in the west San Fernando Valley Assembly seat left vacant when Matt Dababneh resigned in December amid sexual misconduct allegations.

"I will be announcing shortly a great opportunity that has come my way at the professional level, and I would like to thank my supporters, especially those from the 3rd Los Angeles Council District," Zine said in a two-paragraph statement.

Campaign consultant Rick Taylor said the "great opportunity" was presented to Zine on Saturday but said specifics won't be announced for a couple of days.

The announcement came hours after a controversy erupted — and seemed to be quickly settled — over the onetime L.A. police officer and current LAPD reserve officer's request to be described as "Police Officer/Volunteer" in the ballot designation. Rival candidate Tricia Robbins Kasson complained about that proposed description, and state election officials said that designation

violated ballot rules. Zine's campaign said about noon Monday that he would instead run without a description.

Three hours later, Zine wasn't running at all.

Taylor said Zine's withdrawal had nothing to do with how his campaign was going in the two weeks since the 70-year-old entered the race.

Zine, a City Council member from 2001 to 2013, when he lost a bid for L.A. city controller, faced questions about sexual harassment allegations lodged against him by a female LAPD officer in 1999, when he was a police union director. Zine was officially absolved of the claim, but disciplinary board member Cmdr. Dan Koenig wrote in the decision that Zine had shown "unbelievably poor judgment."

Zine's name will remain on the ballot in Assembly District 45, the California secretary of state's office said.

Robbins Kasson campaign consultant Larry Levine said it's not impossible that Zine could drop back into the race later.

"I would challenge him to send a mailer to the voters to say, 'I have withdrawn my name. Do not vote for me,' " Levine said. "Until that happens, I'm skeptical."

Eight candidates met the Feb. 8 deadline to enter the April 3 election and qualified for the ballot: Zine; Democrats Robbins Kasson (ballot designation: "Economic Development Director"), Jesse Gabriel ("Constitutional Rights Attorney"), Ankur Patel ("Teacher/LAUSD Coordinator"), Daniel Brin ("Neighborhood Council President"), Ray Bishop ("Small Business Owner") and Jeff Bornstein ("Small Business Owner"), and Republican Justin Clark (no designation).

If nobody gets an outright majority, the top two will advance to a runoff June 5, which also is the date of the primary for the election for the next two-year term.

C.R. Cochrane also entered but did not qualify for the ballot, election officials said. That leaves Robbins Kasson, an aide to L.A. City Councilman Bob Blumenfield, as the only woman in the race at a time when the #MeToo movement has made the empowerment of women a cause for many voters.

The Secretary of State's Office is scheduled to certify the candidates Wednesday for April 3 special elections for Assembly seats formerly represented by Dababneh, Raul Bocanegra and Sebastian Ridley-Thomas.

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